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Easier for Whom? The Alberta.ca Account

What you need to know about the system the government is building, and the Albertans being left out of it

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A NOTE BEFORE READING.

This report is about the system the Government of Alberta is increasingly using to gate access to government services — the Alberta.ca Account. It is being framed as a convenience. It is being recommended as the alternative when other channels fail. It is being held up as the path forward.

It is not equally available to everyone. The verification chain that converts a basic account into a verified one — which is what's required to actually access personal records, including AISH files — locks out a substantial portion of the Albertans who most need access. This document lays out who, why, and what that means.

WHAT THIS REPORT IS ASKING

The Government of Alberta has been pushing Albertans to create Alberta.ca Accounts — increasingly as a precondition for accessing government services and personal information. The framing is consistent: easier, faster, more secure, more convenient.

The question this report asks is simple: **easier for whom?**

Because the system that is “easier” for one population is structurally inaccessible for another. And the population for whom it is inaccessible is, with striking regularity, the population that already faces the most barriers to government services in the first place: disabled Albertans, low-income seniors, people without permanent housing, people without smartphones, people whose identification documents are out of date, people in rural and remote communities, people with cognitive disabilities or low literacy, and people who — particularly after the events of late April 2026 — no longer trust the government with centralized identity infrastructure.

This is not a theoretical concern. The verification chain that the system requires is documented. The exclusions are known. The numbers are public. What is missing is the willingness to name what those numbers mean.

SECTION ONE — WHAT THE ALBERTA.CA ACCOUNT IS

The Alberta.ca Account is a single sign-on digital identity issued by the Government of Alberta. It is the credential the government is consolidating around to gate access to provincial services online. It was previously known as *MyAlberta Digital ID*; the name was changed to Alberta.ca Account, but the system underneath is the same.

There are two account types:

- **Basic Account.** Requires only a personal email address. Cannot access personal records or services that require proof of identity. Useful for some services; not useful for ATIA file requests, MyHealth Records, or anything personal.

- **Verified Account.** Required for accessing personal information through the portal. This is the account type recommended as the “alternative” to email submission of ATIA personal file requests.

To be useful for accessing your AISH file, your medical records, or your other personal information, the account must be verified.

SECTION TWO — TIMELINE

The system has been in place for over a decade.

2015 — MyAlberta Digital ID launched. Basic accounts available.

2017 — Verified Account capability added, requiring an Alberta driver’s licence or Alberta identification card.

2022 — Alberta Student Aid migrates to require Verified Account access.

2024 — System rebranded from MyAlberta Digital ID to Alberta.ca Account.

2025 — Alberta Wallet and Mobile Health Card announced, with plans for a combined health-care/driver’s-licence plastic card.

2026 — The Alberta.ca Account becomes the recommended channel for ATIA personal file requests, including AISH files, ahead of the July 1, 2026 ADAP transition.

The system is not new. The push to make it the default channel for access to personal records is.

SECTION THREE — THE VERIFICATION CHAIN

To obtain a Verified Account, every one of the following conditions must be true. If any one of them is not, online verification fails and the user must visit an Alberta Registry Agent in person.

- 1. A valid (non-expired, or expired less than 6 months) Alberta driver’s licence OR Alberta identification card.** If the user has neither, they cannot obtain a Verified Account at all.
- 2. The address on the ID must match the user’s current residence.** If the user has moved without updating the ID, online verification fails.
- 3. A mobile phone number registered with the Alberta Registry** for SMS or phone-call verification. Landline phones cannot receive SMS. If the phone is not registered, the only remaining option is mail, which takes up to 10 business days to receive a verification code.
- 4. A personal email address not shared with anyone else.** Shared family email addresses are explicitly discouraged.
- 5. Permanent residency in Alberta.** Albertans without a permanent address (people in shelters, transitional housing, fleeing violence, or unhoused) cannot obtain the ID required to verify, and therefore cannot obtain a Verified Account.

If the user's information is out of date — wrong address, wrong name, expired ID — the only fix is an in-person visit to an Alberta Registry Agent. This requires transportation, the registry fee (currently \$26 for an ID card, up to \$98 for a driver's licence), and the wait for a new card to arrive in the mail. The Government of Alberta's own documentation states that *"making changes to these documents, and then having to restart the process of verifying your Alberta.ca Account could take 90 days or more."*

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE.

If you don't have a current driver's licence or ID card. If your address is out of date. If you don't have a smartphone. If your phone number isn't registered with the Registry. If you don't have a permanent address. If your only email is one you share with a family member. If any one of those things is true for you, the "alternative" online portal isn't actually an alternative.

SECTION FOUR — THE NUMBERS

The Government of Alberta has reported the following figures for Alberta.ca Account adoption:

3.5M
TOTAL ACTIVE ACCOUNTS

2.1M
VERIFIED ACCOUNTS

~2.7M
WITHOUT VERIFIED ACCOUNT

Alberta's population is approximately 4.85 million. With roughly 2.1 million Verified Accounts, that means approximately **2.7 million Albertans — about 56 percent of the province — do not have a Verified Account.**

For each of those 2.7 million people, the "use the online portal" alternative requires first completing the verification chain described above before they can begin the actual ATIA request, the AISH file access, or the medical record retrieval. For many of them, the verification chain cannot be completed at all, no matter how much time they put into it.

This is the population the government's "alternative" leaves behind. It is not a small population. It is more than half the province.

SECTION FIVE — WHO THE SYSTEM LEAVES OUT

The exclusions are not random. They follow a pattern, and the pattern follows the demographics of Alberta's most marginalized communities.

People without an Alberta driver's licence or ID card.

Many disabled Albertans do not drive. Many low-income Albertans never obtained an ID card because the cost (currently \$26 for the card itself, plus transportation to a registry agent) was a barrier. Many newcomers do not yet have provincial ID. Without one or the other, a Verified Account is not available. The government's own documentation says so explicitly.

People without permanent housing.

Obtaining either form of Alberta ID requires a permanent address as proof of residency. Albertans living in shelters, transitional housing, supportive housing without a fixed unit, hospital-based residential programs, or those who are unhoused cannot obtain the ID, cannot verify the account, and cannot use the portal. The system does not offer an alternative.

Seniors, particularly those in long-term care.

Government of Canada research has documented persistent digital divides among seniors, with lower usage rates among low-income seniors, those in rural and remote areas, older immigrants, and seniors with physical disabilities or cognitive impairments. The same research notes that long-term care and retirement homes face specific barriers including residents' physical capability, cognitive understanding, and inadequate infrastructure. The Verified Account chain — driver's licence, registered phone, current email, multi-step web flow — assumes a level of digital fluency that many seniors do not have.

Albertans with cognitive disabilities, learning disabilities, or low literacy.

The verification process is multi-step and requires reading, comprehension, document handling, and navigating between web pages, email, and SMS or postal mail. Each step is a point at which the process can fail. For people with cognitive disabilities, learning disabilities, traumatic brain injuries, or low literacy, the cumulative cognitive load is itself a barrier — even before any of the other conditions become a problem.

People without smartphones or reliable phone service.

SMS-based verification requires a registered mobile number. Phone-call verification requires a registered landline. People with prepaid phones, frequently changed phone plans, or no phone at all are pushed to the mail option, which takes up to 10 business days plus mail delivery delays. For someone trying to file an ATIA request before the July 1, 2026 ADAP transition, that delay alone may exceed the time available.

Albertans whose ID information is out of date.

Anyone who has moved recently, changed their name, or whose ID has expired more than six months ago cannot complete online verification. They must visit a Registry Agent in person — which itself requires transportation, money, and time. The Government of Alberta's documentation explicitly warns that the round trip can take "90 days or more" before the account is verified.

Albertans in rural, remote, and Indigenous communities.

Internet infrastructure remains inconsistent in many rural Alberta communities, and significantly weaker in many Indigenous communities. The Government of Alberta itself committed \$390 million to rural broadband over four years in Budget 2022 in recognition of the gap. That gap has not yet closed. People without reliable broadband cannot complete an online verification process, regardless of whether they have all the other prerequisites.

Disabled Albertans currently on AISH.

The AISH-to-ADAP transition, effective July 1, 2026, affects approximately 79,290 disabled Albertans. Many of them sit at the intersection of multiple categories above: chronic conditions that prevent driving, fixed incomes that make Registry visits a financial decision, complex medication and care schedules that consume the cognitive capacity required to navigate a multi-step verification flow, and a documented administrative attrition pattern that punishes those who cannot keep up. The very population being asked to file ATIA requests in advance of the transition is the population least likely to be able to use the online portal alternative.

SECTION SIX — THE TRUST PROBLEM

The Alberta.ca Account is being expanded at a moment when public trust in government-held centralized identity data has been demonstrably broken.

On April 30, 2026, Elections Alberta confirmed that the personal information of **2.9 million Albertans** — including names, addresses, postal codes, and elector identification numbers — had been improperly distributed from a List of Electors provided to the Republican Party of Alberta to a separatist mobilization organization called The Centurion Project. The Centurion Project has documented ties to the U.S. MAGA movement. The Court of King's Bench granted Elections Alberta a temporary injunction. The RCMP launched a criminal investigation. The Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner of Alberta is reviewing the case.

Elections Alberta itself identified **marginalized communities** — including domestic violence survivors, law enforcement personnel, and people whose addresses are connected to specific medical or supportive services — as among those at significant risk of harm. Disabled Albertans, particularly those in supportive housing, those receiving home care, and those in shelters fleeing violence, are part of those marginalized communities.

The breach happened nine days before this report was written.

In the weeks since, the Government of Alberta has continued to recommend that Albertans create Alberta.ca Accounts as the alternative to the bouncing email channel for ATIA submissions. The government's response to a documented breach affecting 2.9 million Albertans is, in functional terms: *"Trust us with even more centralized identity infrastructure. Link your driver's licence, register your phone, share your email, and use this single sign-on credential to access your most sensitive records."*

THE MATH PEOPLE ARE DOING.

If 2.9 million Albertans' voter information moved out of an Elections Alberta database into the hands of a partisan mobilization organization in April, the rational response in May is not to hand the same government a richer, more consolidated identity profile linked to medical, financial, and disability records. That is not paranoia. That is an Albertan paying attention.

SECTION SEVEN — A HEALTHCARE MIGRATION CASE STUDY

The pattern is broader than government services. It is also playing out across Alberta's healthcare system.

Specialist clinics, hospital outpatient programs, and pharmacy services are increasingly migrating their patient communications to the Alberta.ca Account / MyHealth Records portal — appointment confirmations, medication pickup notifications, lab and test results, treatment scheduling. The transition is often unannounced, and the only way to preserve phone communication is to know in advance the migration is coming and pre-emptively request it.

For patients on time-sensitive treatments — chronic conditions requiring infusion therapy, immunoglobulin replacement, regular bloodwork, scheduled specialist follow-ups — a missed portal notification has direct health consequences. A medication pickup that is not collected on time may not be available the next time it is needed. An appointment that is not confirmed may be released to another patient.

The “benefit” of the portal — that patients can access their lab results and clinical notes — is also unevenly distributed. The patient-portal research literature has documented that providing raw lab results to patients without clinical interpretation produces measurable rates of patient distress, misunderstanding, and unnecessary anxiety. For health-literate patients with stable conditions, portal access is genuinely useful. For everyone else, raw clinical data without context can produce more confusion than clarity.

What portal migration does deliver, reliably and across both healthcare and government contexts, is operational efficiency for the institution: reduced phone-staff costs, automated appointment reminders, lower no-show rates, and the ability to claim modernization. Those are real benefits, but they are not patient benefits. They are system benefits, dressed in the language of patient empowerment.

SECTION EIGHT — THE DISCONNECT

The Alberta government's framing of the Alberta.ca Account is consistent: easier, more secure, more convenient, available to everyone. The lived reality, for the populations most affected, is something different at every step:

- **“Easier”** — easier for whom. Easier for the people who already have a current driver's licence, registered phone, fixed address, and broadband at home. Not easier for anyone else.
- **“More secure”** — more secure than what. More secure than mailing a signed paper form to a Registry address that has not changed in twenty years? Or more secure than an Elections Alberta voter list, which

moved 2.9 million Albertans' personal data out the door nine days ago?

- **“More convenient”** — more convenient than picking up a phone, which is what was already being done before the migration began. The convenience is in the migration, not in the destination.
- **“Available to everyone”** — only if “everyone” is defined as the 44 percent of Albertans who already have a Verified Account. The other 56 percent are not addressed by that sentence.

The government does not lie about the system. It just doesn't talk about who the system is not for. The disconnect is in what is being left out — which is the same population that is left out of nearly every administrative migration the campaign has documented over the past year.

To the Albertans the government's framing leaves out:

The homeless person being told to “just use the online portal” cannot use it, because they cannot get the ID required to verify the account. We see you.

The senior in long-term care whose specialist now communicates only through a portal she cannot navigate cannot keep up with her own healthcare. We hear you.

The Albertan with low literacy or a cognitive disability who cannot complete the multi-step verification flow is not stupid, lazy, or unwilling. The system was not built for them. We see you.

The disabled Albertan on AISH whose ID is out of date and who cannot get to a Registry Agent before the July transition is being told an “alternative” exists when, structurally, it does not. We hear you.

The Albertan who, after the April 30 voter list breach, no longer trusts the government with centralized identity data is not paranoid. They are paying attention. We see you.

You deserve accessibility — not the version that's easier for the system. The version that's built for you.

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT ASKS

This document does not ask Albertans to refuse the Alberta.ca Account. For people who can use it without barrier, it is a legitimate option. The campaign has consistently held that all access channels should be available, accessible, and reliable.

This document asks the Government of Alberta to do three things:

- 1. Maintain functional non-digital channels.** Mail, fax, and phone submission for ATIA requests, government services, and healthcare communication must remain reliably available — not as deprecated relics waiting to be retired, but as equally legitimate options. The bouncing of the SARTR.ATI-CentralIntake email channel — currently the subject of a formal complaint to the Office of the Information and Privacy Commissioner — is the kind of failure this document is asking to prevent.
- 2. Be honest about who the digital system is not for.** Public communication that names the Alberta.ca Account as the alternative should also name, in the same breath, who that alternative does not work for and what those Albertans should do instead.
- 3. Restore trust before consolidating identity infrastructure.** No further digital identity expansion should proceed until the April 30, 2026 voter list breach has been fully investigated, the Foreign Influence Transparency Commissioner has reviewed the connections, and accountability has been documented. The expansion of centralized identity infrastructure on top of an unaddressed breach is not modernization. It is the deepening of a problem that has not yet been fixed.

This document is part of the campaign's documentary record, alongside the Compound Failure Brief, the Information Asymmetry Report, the Cage Doesn't End series, and the Building Up legislative blueprint. The pattern across all of them is the same: the system as designed works well for some Albertans, and the people for whom it does not work are the same people, every time.

WHERE THE FULL RECORD IS.

The full campaign library — including the Compound Failure Brief, the Information Asymmetry Report, the Cage Doesn't End series, Building Up: Alberta Accessibility and Inclusion Blueprint, and the OIPC complaint about the bouncing ATI Coordinator email — is available at albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app. Free to download. Free to share. Free to print.

Speak up. Speak out. Be heard.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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